

Sprint 1: Market Research

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Summary

The team started Sprint 1 with five candidate problems and talked to 51 people about them in two phases. Phase 1 (26 interviews across all five) cut the field to two. Phase 2 (25 interviews on the survivors) reversed the Phase 1 ranking: the nutrition candidate that had looked strongest did not hold up under a broader sample, and the events candidate that had looked weak sharpened into a specific, repeated ask. The project the team is taking forward is **Candidate 3: a single place to see what is happening in El Paso, before it happens.**

Three patterns showed up across everything the team researched, not just the winner. Anything that depends on daily manual logging dies within weeks. The pain people can actually describe is finding out too late, whether it is a protein shortfall at 10 pm, a concert that already happened, or a rental fee for a film they already had. And where a free incumbent already works well enough, people do not want another app.

How the research was done

The method was customer discovery under Mom Test rules: ask about the last time something happened, not whether an idea sounds good; never pitch; record participants by role, never by name. Each conversation went on a guided sheet with a body of five or six questions, follow-up probes, verbatim quotes and a one-sentence takeaway written within 24 hours.

Phase	When	Interviews	Candidates	Who
Phase 1	Sep 3 to 7	26	All five (5, 5, 6, 5, 5)	Emmanuel Saenz (C1), Samuel Alderete (C2), Jazmin Huerta (C3), Oscar Vargas (C4), Christian Lopez-Matulesy (C5)
Scoping checkpoint	Sep 8		Cut to two: Candidates 2 and 3	Team
Phase 2	Sep 9	25	Candidate 2 (13), Candidate 3 (12)	Oscar Vargas, Jazmin Huerta, Christian Lopez-Matulesy (C2); Samuel Alderete, Emmanuel Saenz, Jazmin Huerta (C3)

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Participants were reached in person: on the UTEP campus, at gyms, outside a construction site, at a restaurant and a bar, at a county courthouse, and, for Candidate 1, in Fort Worth. Everyone consented to notes and to a later follow-up.

1. Aggregate findings

1.1 Manual logging dies within weeks, in every category we tested

This was the one finding that crossed candidate lines. In the finance conversations, three of five people had started a spreadsheet or template and stopped inside a month ("by the third week I ended up getting lazy and just stopped"). In nutrition, all five Phase 1 participants had quit a tracking app within one to four weeks, and four of the five Phase 2 participants who had tried an app had quit it too, over exams, forgotten snacks, or homemade food they could not estimate. The people who kept going were the ones who had removed the logging: the contractor with a spreadsheet he built himself, the nurse with cash envelopes, the meal-prepper who eats the same five lunches.

The implication for any candidate: a product that needs the user to enter things every day inherits this churn on day one.

1.2 The pain people can describe is finding out too late

When participants were asked for the last time something went wrong, the stories had the same shape across three candidates. The construction worker "checks at night and I'm still 700 or 800 calories under." The student who "found out about a car show after seeing people's pictures from it that night." The person who rented Dune 2 for six dollars and "found out later it was on Max, which my girlfriend pays for." The feeling is the same: the information existed, and it arrived after the moment it was useful.

1.3 The information exists; it does not reach people

For events specifically, nobody said El Paso lacks things to do. They said they do not hear about them. Announcements live on the Instagram pages of the venue, the organizer, or an aggregator account like FitFam, and only reach the people already following the right ones. "Unless you follow the exact business or page hosting it, you might never see it." People without social media, or who use it lightly, are cut off almost entirely: "since I don't have social media, I don't have an easy way to get to this information."

1.4 A free incumbent that works beats a better idea

Where a good-enough free tool existed, participants used it and felt no problem. The engineer's credit card already categorizes purchases. Three Phase 2 nutrition participants find MyFitnessPal encouraging and sufficient. The streaming problem, the one with the strongest evidence of wasted money, is already served by JustWatch and Reelgood at no cost. This is why Candidate 5 was dropped despite its evidence, and it is a bar Candidate 3 has to clear: for the heavy Instagram user with a curated feed, "Instagram already puts everything in one feed for me, so it doesn't really bother me."

1.5 Questions about opinions produce opinions

The Candidate 4 (investing education) interviews are the clearest lesson in method. The questions asked what people knew, feared and would want, and every answer was a hypothetical: "I think if it can clearly explain things to beginners I would try it out." Not one participant described a past attempt to invest or learn.

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The candidate was dropped less for a weak market than for evidence that could not have disconfirmed anything.

2. Top pick: Candidate 3, an events hub for El Paso

2.1 What we tested

The problem statement as written on the sheets: *people find it hard to find events and places to go to in El Paso/Juárez, often finding out after the events have already happened.*

2.2 Phase 1: a real problem, a weak signal

Six conversations. All six could name an event they had missed, which put the problem on the board. But only two of six said it happens often, and three said they do not look for events at all; things arrive through a feed or a friend or a spouse. Two of the six described finding events easy once they had followed enough accounts. Ranked against Candidate 2's five-for-five Phase 1, this looked like the weaker survivor, and the team carried it into Phase 2 mainly because the missed-event stories were so specific.

2.3 Phase 2: the signal sharpened

The Phase 2 question set was tightened around past behavior: the last public event you attended and how you heard about it, where you look for details, the last time you found out too late and how often that happens, and one open question about what you would change. Twelve conversations, six of them with working professionals rather than students.

#	Participant	How often they find out too late	What they would change
1	UTEP student, regular at markets and concerts	Once or twice a month	One place to see everything happening that weekend
2	College student who plans weekends with friends	"Pretty often"	Hearing about things at least a week ahead
3	UTEP student who goes out often	"Enough that I've noticed"	El Paso and Juárez together; discovery beyond what the feed already shows
4	Student with limited social media use	Every couple of months	Events by date, without needing Instagram
5	Student with a heavily curated Instagram feed	Rarely (recorded as a weak signal)	Filtering by type of event
6	Software specialist	Could not say: "I'm not aware of them"	Tell it your interests, have it tell you what is on
7	Social worker	A few times a year (sold-out concert, full race registration)	A standardized source, though "how would people find out about it"
8	Attorney	A couple of times	Advertising beyond social media

#	Participant	How often they find out too late	What they would change
9	County worker	Never; a spouse finds their events	No suggestion
10	Victim advocate	About once a year (tickets gone by the time they hear)	A weekly round-up or calendar from official accounts
11	Paralegal	Rarely; follows enough accounts	One source; an interest-based email digest
12	Aerospace engineer, regular event-goer	At least once a month, "every three weeks on average"	A central listing, like the weekly page that used to exist and stopped

Read strictly: six of twelve miss events they would have attended on a recurring basis (monthly, to a few times a year), four say rarely, and two gave no usable frequency. That is not everyone, and the document should not claim it is. What did converge was the answer to the open question. Seven of twelve, in their own words and without being offered the idea, asked for a single place to see what is coming: "there isn't one place where I can just see everything happening that weekend"; "El Paso lacks a one-source location"; "there used to be a page that would put all of the events that were going on every week, but they stopped doing that." Three asked for interest-based filtering. Two asked for lead time of about a week. Two asked for reach beyond social media.

2.4 Who is underserved

Three groups fell out of both phases.

1. **People who rely on word of mouth.** They hear about things from a cousin, a classmate, a spouse, and they are the ones who find out from the photos. This is the largest group in the sample and the one with the strongest stories.
2. **People with little or no social media.** Two Phase 2 participants and one Phase 1 participant. Google gives them "tourist attractions or places that are always open instead of actual events happening that weekend." The attorney's fix was a sign by the road. They are the clearest gap in what exists today.
3. **People with a curated feed who want less noise, not more.** They find events easily and would use filtering by interest. They are the least likely early adopters and the strongest reminder that a feed is the incumbent to beat.

2.5 Where people look today, and where it fails

Channel	What it does well	Where it fails, in participants' words
Instagram and TikTok	Everything is posted there, eventually	Only shows what you already follow; "keeps showing me the same type of stuff"; useless without an account
FitFam and similar aggregator accounts	One place many locals check	Still one account's curation; participants who did not follow it did not know it existed

Channel	What it does well	Where it fails, in participants' words
Facebook events	Notifies when friends are going	Skewed to whoever posts there; fading among students
Google	Finds details once you know the name	Returns places, not events: "it doesn't really show me everything that's actually happening"
Ticketmaster, artist accounts	Big shows	Only big shows, and only if you follow the artist; tickets gone before you hear
Flyers, QR codes, road signs	Reach people offline	Localized to one coffee shop's wall or one road
A weekly listing page (now defunct)	Exactly what people asked for	It stopped

2.6 What the evidence does not support

- **That everyone has this problem.** Four of twelve Phase 2 participants rarely miss events, and the heavy Instagram user is satisfied. The pitch is for the underserved groups above, not for everyone in El Paso.
- **That the interviews alone establish Juárez as required scope.** Participants split. One wants both sides together in one place; another does not cross at all ("I feel it's still too violent"). Six of the twelve Phase 2 interviews describe El Paso venues only, so the research did not settle Juárez on its own. The Project Charter later makes the management decision to include both El Paso and Juárez in scope.
- **That the sample represents the city.** Twelve people, half of them students, interviewed on one day. Phase 1's six Candidate 3 sheets do not record who was interviewed or where.

3. What didn't work, and what we pivoted from

3.1 Candidate 1: money already spoken for (dropped after Phase 1)

Five interviews in Fort Worth. Three participants had abandoned manual expense logging, which is real, but nobody described the stated problem of not knowing how much income was already committed. Two of the five had no financial pain at all and said so. The evidence pointed at a different problem than the one on the sheet, and one that budgeting apps already fight over.

3.2 Candidate 4: Market Master (dropped after Phase 1)

See finding 5. Five participants, five sets of hypotheticals, no past behavior. Dropped for the quality of what could be learned as much as for the market.

3.3 Candidate 5: searching across streaming services (dropped after Phase 1)

The strongest Phase 1 evidence of any candidate: three of five had paid to rent or buy something a service they already subscribed to carried, and all five described giving up on choosing something to watch. Dropped anyway, on scope and incumbents. Availability data across five services is not obtainable by a student team, and JustWatch and Reelgood already do the search for free. Good evidence for a problem the team could not build a defensible answer to.

3.4 Candidate 2: eating toward a body goal (ranked first after Phase 1, dropped after Phase 2)

Phase 1 made this the favorite: all five participants had quit macro tracking within four weeks, all five described finding out at the end of the day that they had fallen short (40 grams of protein; 700 to 800 calories; enough calories but almost no protein), and all five named advance meal preparation as what made their best week work. It also scored best on scope (arithmetic over a food database) and on monetization (a proven category). The team recorded one limitation at the time: every participant had been recruited because they already tracked macros, so the sample could confirm the problem but could not disconfirm it.

Phase 2 fixed the sample and the problem did not survive it. Of thirteen participants, three had never or barely tracked, three tracked loosely, two long-term app users find MyFitnessPal encouraging and sufficient, and four had tracked and quit for the logging-burden reasons in finding 1. Not one described the specific problem on the sheet, not being able to tell in advance whether the day's meals would hit the target. What recurred instead was logging burden, which is exactly the ground MyFitnessPal and MacroFactor already compete on, and the churn the team's own Phase 1 had demonstrated (five of five quit) would be the team's churn too.

The team also weighed positioning. Candidate 2 is a proven but crowded category, and inside the course it was the consensus pick among several teams, which left no room to differentiate.

3.5 What the method got wrong, and what changed

- **Phase 1 grid sheets.** Candidates 3, 4 and 5 were captured in a question-by-interview grid with no interviewer, date, role or one-sentence takeaway per conversation. The answers are there; the synthesis is not. Phase 2 used one guided sheet per interview for everything, which is why its evidence is stronger.
- **Question design between phases.** The Candidate 3 questions were rewritten around "the last time" and "how often," which produced the frequency table above. The Candidate 2 questions moved the other way, toward "have you found tracking encouraging or discouraging," and produced more feelings than stories. Some of the weaker Phase 2 nutrition signal may be the questions rather than the market.
- **Geography.** Six Phase 2 interviews record their location as a county courthouse without naming the city. The participants describe El Paso venues and events, but the sheets should say so.
- **The per-person floor.** The assignment asked for at least five interviews per member. In Phase 2 the team distributed 25 across two candidates and one member finished with four.
- **One answer, five directions.** The open "change one thing" question produced five different product directions: aggregation, lead time, combining El Paso and Juárez, a date view without Instagram, and interest filters. Aggregation was the most common and is the core; the rest are scoping decisions for the charter.

4. Open questions carried into the charter

These are the questions the research carried into chartering. The Project Charter resolves the first by including both El Paso and Juárez; the rest continue into planning and later sprints.

1. Is Juárez in scope for the first version, or is this an El Paso product first? Resolved in the Project Charter: both El Paso and Juárez are in scope.

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2. Where do the events come from: organizer submissions, curation by the team, or scraping public posts?
Participant 7's question stands: how would people find out about the place that lists everything?
3. Which underserved group is first: word-of-mouth dependents, or people without social media?
4. What lead time is the product promising? Participants said about a week.
5. Which categories on day one? The sample mentioned markets, car meets and card shows, concerts, comedy, races, trivia nights and kermeses.

Revision History

Version	Date	Changes
v1.0	Sep 10, 2026	First synthesis of both interview phases, for team review.
v1.1	Sep 15, 2026	Phase 1 interviewers for Candidates 3, 4 and 5 added from the team's record; the grid sheets did not carry them.
v1.2	Sep 21, 2026	Reviewed and approved by the team as written; the review notes come off the page.
v1.3	Sep 21, 2026	The Juárez finding now separates what the interviews showed from the scope the Project Charter later set, and the first open question is marked resolved. The sentence attributing the choice of Candidate 3 to the team's interest is removed.